

Edu-larp @ CHI

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ABSTRACT

Role-play has long been used as an active learning technique in educational and training contexts. In particular, Edu-larp (a structured, live action roleplay experience that teaches through social enactment and reflection [1]) has been used in therapeutic contexts, training courses, and even an entire course curriculum [4]. We propose to host a workshop at CHI 2023 which will connect CHI attendees of various disciplines interested in this topic, with the outcome to understand how edu-larp might be an effective way of augmenting existing teaching and research within HCI. During the workshop, attendees will participate in numerous edu-larp exercises designed to introduce and orient them to the concept, and facilitate discussion about the different ways edu-larp can be leveraged in the broad domain of HCI.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Collaborative and social computing**; **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

KEYWORDS

edu-larp, roleplay, research, design, pedagogy, human-computer interaction

ACM Reference Format:

Raquel Robinson, Karin Johansson, James Fey, Elena Márquez Segura, Jon Back, Annika Waern, Sarah Lynne Bowman, and Katherine Isbister. 2023. Edu-larp @ CHI. In *Extended Abstracts of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human*

Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '23), April 23–28, 2023, Hamburg, Germany. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 5 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3544549.3573819>

1 INTRODUCTION

An Edu-larp is a semi-structured role-playing activity, in which participants engage a subject matter by taking on particular roles and/or personas and enacting situations and scenarios to create immersive learning [1]. Edu-larps are often associated with formal learning in schools, but larp as an educational method and as a tool for experiential learning [8], can also be implemented more broadly; in professional design teams, stakeholder groups, at museums, and other semi-formal venues. Larp is a long-standing format of collective play, which has applications as an active learning technique in educational and training contexts [4], for therapy and training exercises [1], and even makes up an entire course curriculum at a school called Østerskov Efterskole in Denmark [1]. In addition, edu-larps have been shown in a variety of contexts to encourage collaboration, and help engage women and other underrepresented groups in the field of HCI [5].

We propose a workshop at the 2023 Conference on Human Factors and Computing Systems (CHI) which will connect CHI attendees of various disciplines interested in this topic, with the outcome to understand how edu-larp might be an effective way of augmenting existing teaching and research within HCI. During the workshop, attendees will participate in numerous edu-larp exercises designed to introduce and orient them to the concept, and facilitate discussion about the different ways edu-larp can be leveraged in the broad domain of HCI.

2 BACKGROUND

Here, we discuss how we can use edu-larp as a tool to understand HCI and how HCI can benefit from edu-larp as a tool to enhance and supplement research and teaching. Edu-larp is here seen as

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CHI EA '23, April 23–28, 2023, Hamburg, Germany

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ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9422-2/23/04.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3544549.3573819>

a broad definition, where we make a distinction between larp for larps own sake (such as the typical spare-time larps, recreation larps and the hobby-aspects of larp) as opposed to larp as a tool to achieve external goals (such as learning about a topic, larps to encourage behavioral changes, larp as a learning tool in different formal and informal settings). Edu-larps would here be when larp is used as a tool to achieve external goals.

Larp has been used in educational contexts to help students learn a range of subject matter from history¹ to healthcare [2], and works at multiple levels to engage learners (cognitively, emotionally, and behaviorally). Bowman notes that larps afford “community building; tactical and social problem solving; and identity exploration” [1]. Larp can also be the main pedagogical tool, as is the case of Østerskov Efterskole, a Danish boarding school in which students learn almost entirely within the context of larp [11]. In these settings, players have the opportunity to take on the role or identity of experts in different fields which results in increased feelings of self confidence in those fields [6]. However, most of these larps are not technology or HCI focused.

Edu-larp is a diverse method to consider for the HCI community from multiple angles. As a tool in innovative design processes, edu-larp inspired scenarios can be used to for instance sensitize design teams to theory [13]. This way of using sensitizing scenarios can for instance open up important design discussions within a team, create a playful and creative atmosphere, and overcome social barriers [12]. Edu-larp can also be used more directly in design processes, as a rapid prototyping tool when developing technology enhanced experiences². It can also be used to investigate new tech in playful ways [10]. Recently, HCI researchers have designed technology for use in larps with the purpose of studying the cultivation of community and connection. In particular, researchers have built wearable technology for larps to help support social interaction [3, 9], demonstrating that wearables can be used to help participants to stay immersed in roleplay [9] and to invite larpers to engage in pro-social, even vulnerable, social interaction that helps to build trust and connection [3].

The HCI community can also bring new knowledge to edu-larp communities, where technology enhancement such as wearables, multisensory hybrid installations, projections and other technologies could act as tools to enhance the experiences as well as the learning effects. For instance, the Swedish company LajvVerkstaden has designed educational larps including projections, soundscapes and other technology enhancements³. Edu-larps can also be a way to teach HCI content in itself - for instance to cultivate an interest in programming [5] (see Figure 1), or could be used as a method when teaching HCI students. It can also be used for playful exploration of HCI related questions in a lot of other venues, as an example the Swedish Museum of Technology used larp methods to let visitors explore the possibility of future zero emission cities⁴.

¹<https://analoggamestudies.org/2016/11/the-mixing-desk-of-larp-history-and-current-state-of-a-design-theory/>

²<https://gamesandsociety.spelldesign.uu.se/2022/06/23/transformativ-play-initiative-seminar-2022-programme-and-registration/>

³<https://lajvverkstaden.se/>

⁴<https://www.tekniskamuseet.se/pa-gang/pasklov/>

3 WORKSHOP PLANS

This workshop will be explorative in nature: attendees will investigate, experience and reflect upon ways that edu-larp can be relevant in an HCI context. Our goal is to build a community of researchers and scholars within the CHI community that are activated around the topic of edu-larping and how it might be used broadly within the context of HCI.

We will begin the workshop with a short introduction/orientation to larp and edu-larps more specifically, followed by a series of design exercises in which participants will participate in 3-4 different edu-larp experiences. The day will conclude with a reflection/debrief, generating new ideas for how edu-larps can be applied within the HCI domain.

3.1 Introduction to larp in relation to HCI

Coming from different backgrounds, and with different larp experience and research interests, the introduction phase will be a means to find common ground and to make those who are new to larp comfortable with concepts and terms relevant for the workshop day. This will be done first via brief introductions of participants and their interest in edularp, and a small presentation by the organizers that covers the aims and goals and practical planning of the day. Then, there will follow a short theoretical background presentation, and an overview of what larp and edu-larp look like around the world, larp communities and different types of edu-larps in different settings. Also some up to date examples of technology in relation to larps and edu-larps will be presented.

3.2 Sensitizing participants to HCI related edu-larps

Next the workshop will move on to a series of sensitizing activities, where participants will break into subgroups to try out a smorgasbord of short versions of different edu-larps connected to HCI themes. The larps will be facilitated and designed by the organizers. The larps will represent different angles on how larp and HCI can interrelate, and the larps will be specifically designed by the organizers for this purpose, by using elements from different previous larp projects the organizers have worked on [5, 13], adapting and highlighting relevant aspects. Participants in the workshop will be able to try out several of these different short larp scenarios, each representing one of the angles (as presented below). Together those scenarios will give the participants hands on experiences of what larps can be and how they can be used in an HCI context, the rest of the workshop will then build on the experiences from this sensitizing phase.

- (1) *Edu-larp as a design tool*: larp as a tool in tech design processes, for instance to sensitize design teams to theory, to do rapid prototyping, or as a tool to investigate user behaviors.
- (2) *Edu-larp as a teaching tool*: Larp as a tool to learn about a specific tech such as wearables, or to encourage people to for instance engage in programming.
- (3) *Tech as a tool to enhance edu-larps*: How technology enhancement can improve different types of edu-larps, for different venues and with different learning goals. How for instance wearables, projections and soundscapes can increase immersion and learning outcomes.



Figure 1: Photos from the social wearables edu-larp (SWEL) camp for middle school girls, designed and deployed by numerous workshop organizers [5].

- (4) *Edu-larp as design fiction*: Larp as exploration of future technologies and societies. How larp and taking on different roles can challenge preconceptions about society, evoke emotions, provoke and give opportunity to immerse in different possible futures. Larp as transformative experiences, in relation to exploring design fiction.

This part of the workshop will combine the practical trying out different larps with fleshed out reflexive phases, where participants and facilitators get a chance to come together and reflect upon purposes, highlight differences and similarities between the larps, as well as identifying and discussing different design choices and how those affects the experiences.

3.3 Design exercise: Exploration of possibilities of larp in an HCI context

After the hands-on experience of how different edu-larps can be designed, and how edu-larps can relate in different ways to HCI, the participants will take their experiences and build on the discussions and reflections from the previous exercise, as they move into the next part of the workshop. Participants will divide into groups, and explore more in depth different ways that larp and HCI can be relevant in interconnection with each other. This will be done by using a workshop format where the participants will create rapid inspirational pitches for innovative larp ideas related to the HCI context. For instance, by developing one angle further, combining them, or finding new angles to explore.

3.4 Pitching and concluding reflection

In this final part of the workshop the participants will present their pitches, and reflect upon each others' designs. The pitches will be brought together and connected to the previous phases of the workshop, thus creating a portfolio of knowledge creation from the workshop. Finally, we will conduct a final meta-reflection on insights and learnings from the workshop day, in which we consolidate the knowledge explored and created during the day, and talk about potential next steps, as well as gather useful resources to share beyond the workshop.

3.5 Workshop Logistics

We intend this workshop to be held in person at the conference venue in Hamburg, Germany in 2023. We plan to ask interested people/teams to submit a short abstract of 3 pages maximum, toward inviting 15-20 participants for attendance at the workshop.

4 ORGANIZERS

Raquel Robinson is a postdoctoral fellow at the University of California, Santa Cruz in the Social and Emotional Technology lab. She obtained her PhD in Computer Science at the University of Saskatchewan in 2022. In her postdoctoral work, Raquel contributes to the design and deployment of an educational live-action role playing camp aimed at fostering computational community amongst middle school girls.

Karin Johansson is a Ph.D. candidate at Uppsala University. Karin has worked several years as a professional edu-larp designer and larp educator, both at the company LajvVerkstaden and at museums. Karin has developed dozens of edu-larps, some technology enhanced, for a wide range of stakeholders and venues. Karin is also running her own design company, focused on innovation projects creating playful learning experiences, and on facilitating design processes for stakeholders developing such experiences. Karin has been very active in the larp community for many years.

James Fey is a Ph.D. candidate at the University of California, Santa Cruz. His research is at the intersection of Maker resources and informal learning. He is currently iteratively developing a wearables toolkit for running a live-action role-play camp aimed at middle-school-age girls, in which campers create social wearables using pre-existing maker hardware.

Elena Márquez Segura is a Beatriz Galindo Distinguished Researcher and Assistant Professor in the DEI Interactive Systems Group Lab, within the Department of Computer Science and Engineering at Universidad Carlos III de Madrid. Her work focuses on designing and studying playful technology-supported experiences for collocated physical and social action; and on embodied design methods facilitating their design. In the past, Elena has been involved in several projects designing and studying technology for larps, and in exploring how and larps can be used instrumentally in the design process.

Jon Back is a Senior Lecturer/Associate Professor at Department

of Informatics and Media at Uppsala University. He is interested in the designing for peoples play with public places. His focus is on how the design affects the engagement, feelings and experiences of the game. Jon previously studied and worked with computer programming and design and moved on towards communication with a pedagogical twist and games as his main tools. He's designed both live action role playing games and published board games, both for serious use and for entertainment.

Annika Waern is a Professor at the Department of Informatics and Media at Uppsala University. She is also a larp designer and organiser. During 2004–2008, she was the coordinator of the EU project IPerG, known for its groundbreaking investigations into pervasive games. Her academic publications primarily focus on the design and study pervasive larp productions such as Momentum and Conspiracy for Good. As a designer, she has also been a contributor to productions exploring novel formats, such as the pervasive interactive performance Interference and the larp musical Cabaret. She has also designed several smaller scenarios, of which some have been featured at Prolog, Sandcon, and Stockholm Scenario festival.

Sarah Lynne Bowman is a professor, event organizer, and game designer. She is currently an Associate Professor at the Department of Game Design at Uppsala University, where she teaches a Certificate track on the use of analog role-playing games as vehicles for personal and social change. She is a founding member of the Transformative Play Initiative research group. Bowman received her Ph.D. from the University of Texas at Dallas in 2008. She also holds a B.S. and M.A. from the University of Texas at Austin in Radio-TV-Film. In 2010, McFarland Press published her dissertation as *The Functions of Role-playing Games: How Participants Create Community, Solve Problems, and Explore Identity*. From 2020–2022, she served as Program Coordinator for Peace & Conflict Studies at Austin Community College, where she currently teaches classes in the Humanities. She served as an editor for *The Wyrld Con Companion Book* from 2012–2015. Bowman is currently is a Coordinating Editor for the *International Journal of Role-playing* and a Managing Editor for *NordicLarp.org*. She was the lead organizer for the Living Games Conference 2016 and helped coordinate the Role-playing and Simulation in Education Conference at Texas State University's St. David's School of Nursing. Bowman also served a central role in organizing iterations of those two conferences in 2018. She is currently co-organizing the Transformative Play Initiative Seminar 2022: Role-playing, Culture, and Heritage in Visby, Sweden.

Katherine Isbister is Professor of Computational Media and Jack Baskin Endowed Chair in Engineering at the University of California, Santa Cruz, where she directs the Social and Emotional Technology Lab. Isbister has written several books, including *How Games Move Us* [7] about the emotional and social connections that games provide. Isbister's research team is engaged in a multi-year NSF-funded project designing an edu-larp camp focused on building middle school girls' computational interest and skills [5].

5 WEBSITE

The workshop website is available at this URL, including the call for participation, instructions for submission, and the goals of the workshop: <https://sites.google.com/view/edu-larpatchi/home>

6 WORKSHOP OUTCOMES

Overall, the goal of this workshop is to bring together a group of people in HCI interested in edu-larp to facilitate conversation and collaboration. At the end of the workshop, we hope to make available a compendium of resources hosted on a website to help facilitate HCI focused edu-larp work.

The pitches of the participants will be brought together in a shareable annotated portfolio format, filled with design explorations and insights from the workshop. In addition, the organizers will gauge interest in participation in future edu-larp focused events, such as a CHI course, or a follow-up workshop.

7 CALL FOR PARTICIPATION

We invite researchers and scholars interested in live-action role-play (larp) to join us for the first edu-larp workshop at CHI 2023. Those interested should submit a proposal (3-pages maximum) outlining their interest in the topic, and a short author biography (one half page). For more information, please visit this website: <https://sites.google.com/view/edu-larpatchi/home> and email your proposal submission to rrobins@ucsc.edu by February 23, 2023.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This work has been partially supported by the Madrid Government (Comunidad de Madrid) under the Multiannual Agreement with UC3M in the line of "Research Funds for Beatriz Galindo Fellowships" (MovIntPlayLab-CM-UC3M), and in the context of the V PRICIT (Regional Programme of Research and Technological Innovation).

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